



JUNKERS JU 88 BOMBSIGHT

German bomb-aiming systems were far superior to those of the RAF in the early stages of the war. German bombers were often fitted with two bomb-sights – one for level bombing, and one for dive or glide bombing.

more than 500 tons of bombs, whereas as early as 1943 the RAF was dropping over 2,000 tons on a single night over Germany. But the Luftwaffe raids were no powder-puff punch. Some 40,000 civilians were killed in the Blitz and local devastation – for example, in London's East End and at Coventry – could be of awesome intensity.

The impact of the Luftwaffe's campaign was undoubtedly limited by the lack of a heavy bomber. The Heinkel He 111 had a maximum bombload of around 4,500lb (2,000kg), well under half that of a four-engined RAF bomber such as the Halifax, and even the Junkers Ju 88 had a maximum load of only 6,600lb (3,000kg). But in other ways the Luftwaffe was much better prepared for a strategic bombing campaign than the RAF.



FIREPROOF

A British poster publicizes the Fire Guard, an organization set up in 1941 to counter the effect of incendiary bombs. Many urban areas were destroyed by fire in the Blitz.

GUIDED DESTRUCTION OF COVENTRY

ON THE EVENING OF November 14, 1940, a dozen Heinkel He 111s took off from Vannes, Brittany, France, to spearhead the bombing of the British industrial city of Coventry. They were part of Kampfgruppe 100, the Luftwaffe's elite pathfinders used to mark targets for the bomber swarms. The Heinkel crews had the X-gerät target-finding system (see page 216).

To find the city itself was child's play for the experienced Heinkel pilots. Tuned in to a *Knickebein* radio beam directed from a transmitter in Brittany to Coventry, the pilot adjusted his course each time the steady hum of the "equisignal" broke up into morse dots or dashes, telling him he was wandering to one side or the other of the beam. Behind the pathfinders, similar beams guided almost 500 other bombers toward the city.

Laid across the *Knickebein* radio beam ahead of Kampfgruppe 100 were three "crossbeams" transmitted from further east. The first alerted the bomber's crew with an "advance signal," telling them they were approaching Coventry.

"The usual cheers that greeted a direct hit stuck in our throats. The crew gazed down on the sea of flames in silence."

LUFTWAFFE PILOT
REMEMBERING THE BOMBING OF COVENTRY

The second beam crossed their course exactly 19 miles (30km) from their preestablished target. It was the signal for the navigator to activate the X-gerät device, a primitive bomb-aiming computer. The third beam was laid 9½ miles

(15km) from the target, giving the signal for pressing another key, setting the X-gerät to automatically release the bombload. As long as the pilot held a steady course, speed, and altitude for the last 15km, the X-gerät would release the bombs directly on the target.

Aware of the Luftwaffe's use of radio beams, the British were frantically attempting to jam or confuse them with electronic countermeasures, but on this occasion they failed. The Heinkels dropped their incendiaries and saw flames flickering across the center of Coventry, marking the target for the fleets of bombers advancing behind them. More than 500 tons of high explosives and incendiaries were dropped on the city in the course of the night. More than 500 people were killed, and over a thousand were injured.

MORNING AFTER

The morning after the bombing raid on Coventry in November 1940, local people go about their business. Over 500 civilians died in the raid, a small number compared with the mass deaths in German and Japanese cities later in the war but a severe shock at the time.

